I recognise that if we could make a clean sweep of the Bolshevik Treaty and of Bolshevik influence from Afghanistan, it would be a serious check for the Bolsheviks and a valuable diplomatic triumph...But it is essential to get a clear-cut idea what it is possible for us to buy.[118]

It would appear, then, that the new viceroy was apt to be as cautious when it came to the issue of Afghanistan and Bolshevik sedition as his predecessor had been. Montagu responded:

In order to achieve the object of getting rid of both the Bolshevik Treaty and the Bolsheviks themselves we would agree to, and indeed urge, your going to the very limit of your financial capacity in this direction. ...we would urge you not to put too low a limit upon the expenditure necessary for the production of a result so greatly to be desired.[119]

Despite Reading's doubts, the temptation to reinstate Britain's hegemony over Afghanistan was just too much for Montagu and the Home government. On 10 May, a meeting of the Cabinet decided 'that an effort should be made to offer Afghanistan sufficient inducement in money and arms to make her throw over the Bolshevik Treaty entirely'.[120]

Through the summer of 1921, then, Dobbs attempted to pin the Afghan government down to an 'exclusive agreement', as it became known, with offers of a subsidy, airplanes, telegraph equipment and munitions, in the event of Russia making an unprovoked attack upon Afghanistan.[121] However, the Afghan government procrastinated over this commitment, asking for the treaty with Britain to be signed and the munitions delivered before it cancelled the agreement with Russia.[122] In July, with still no exclusive treaty signed, Dobbs suggested that Amanullah could simply be playing a game: drawing out the negotiations until its treaty with Soviet Russia could be ratified and it had received Soviet aid, at which point it would break off with Britain.[123] Reading was a little more gracious towards